What You'll Do

1. Download and set up a free ngrok account
2. Run your local ASP.NET website in Visual Studio
3. Create a secure public tunnel to your local server
4. Share your live website link with others

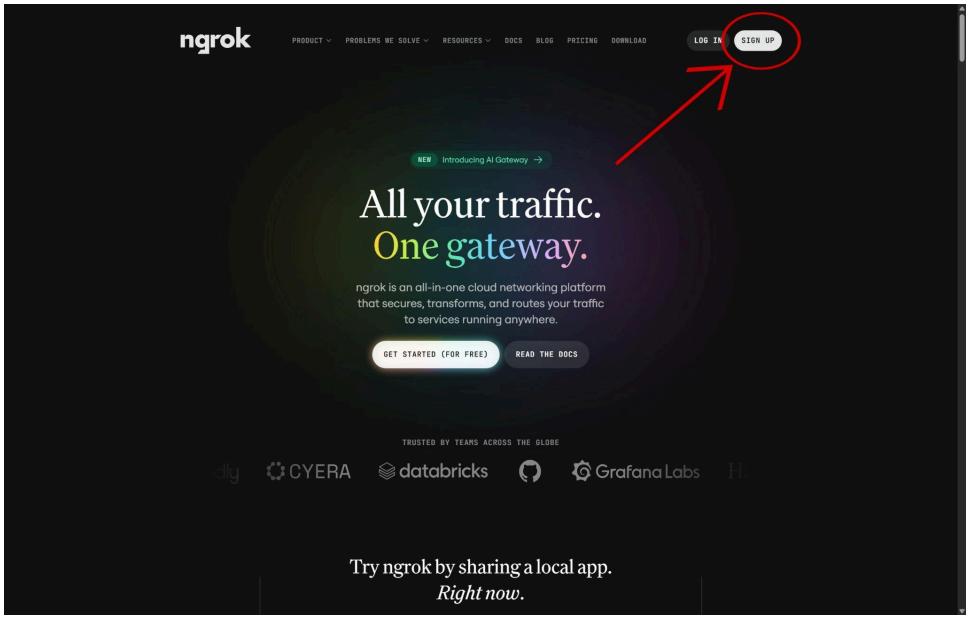
What You Need

- Visual Studio 2022
- Your ASP.NET project files
- Internet connection
- Command Prompt (Or terminal app on Mac)
- 5 minutes of setup time

Step 1: Get ngrok Ready

1.1 Sign Up

- Visit: https://ngrok.com/
- Click “Sign Up” and create a free account.

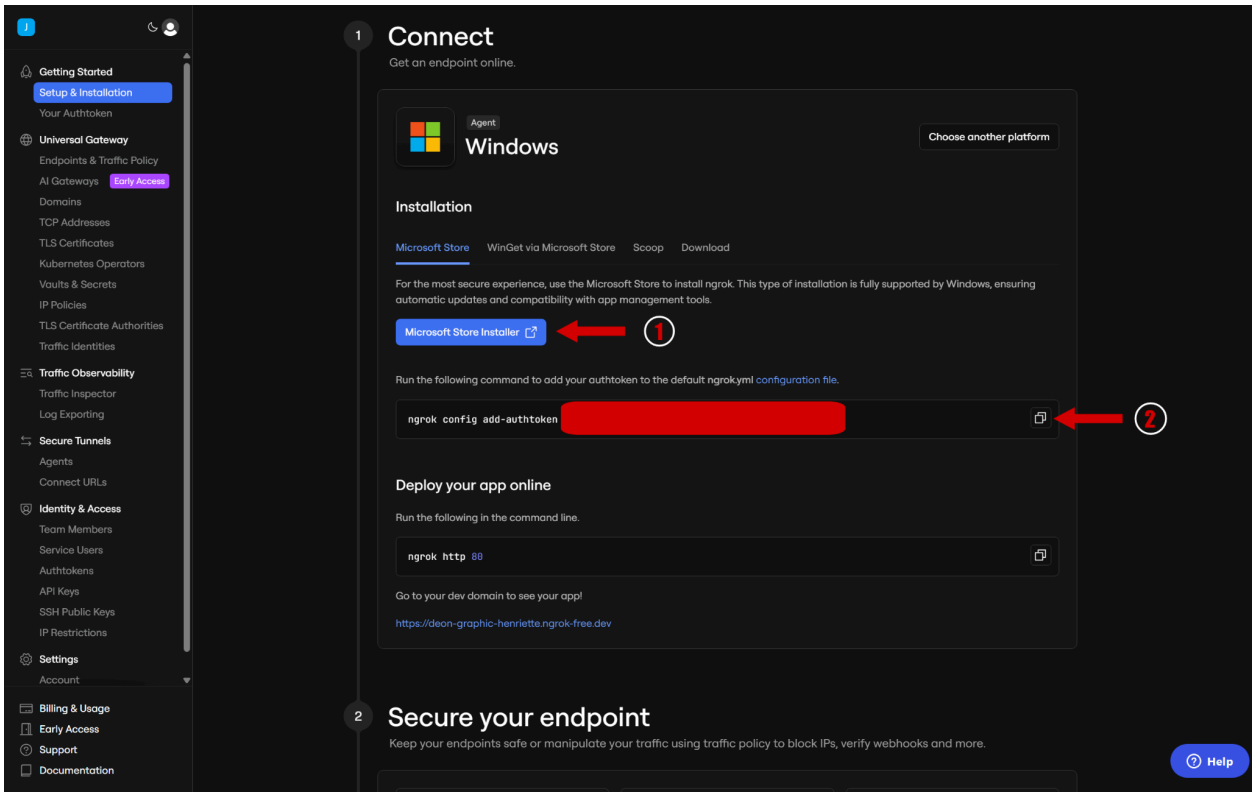


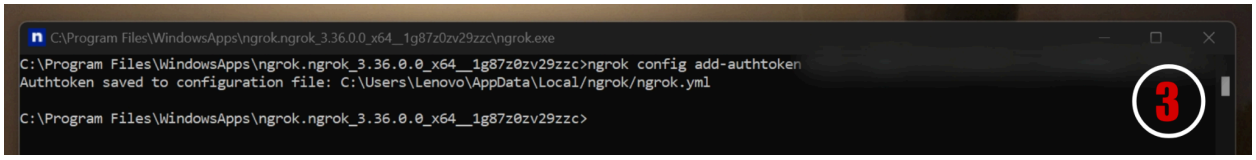
1.2 Download ngrok

- Once logged in, click “Microsoft Store Installer” and download ①.
- Find the ngrok.exe file in the install location.

1.3 Authenticate (First time only)

- Go to your ngrok online dashboard.
- Look for the section titled "Connect your account" to find your unique Authtoken command ②.
- Double click on the ngrok.exe file.
- Paste your specific Authtoken command and press Enter ③.





Step 2: Run Your Local Server

2.1 Open Your Project

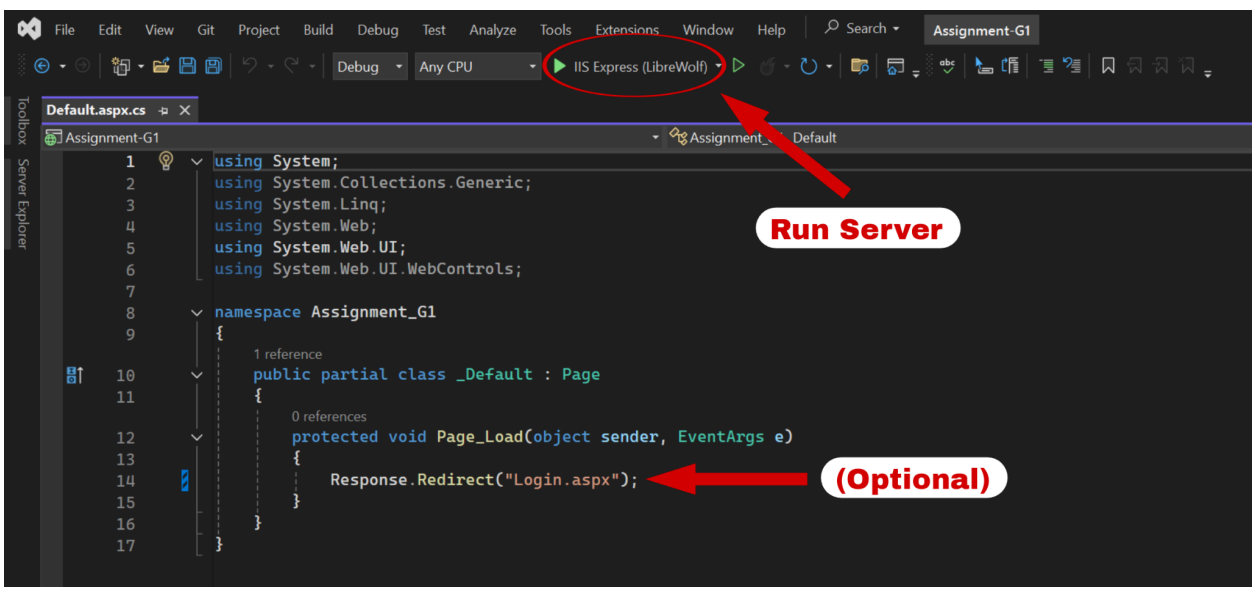
- Open Visual Studio 2022.
- Open your project solution file.

2.2 Change Default File (Optional)

- By default, Ngrok will automatically be running the `Default.aspx` file once you create the link in Step 3. If you want the link to lead to another page instead (e.g., `Login.aspx`), edit `Default.aspx.cs` to automatically redirect to the page you want.

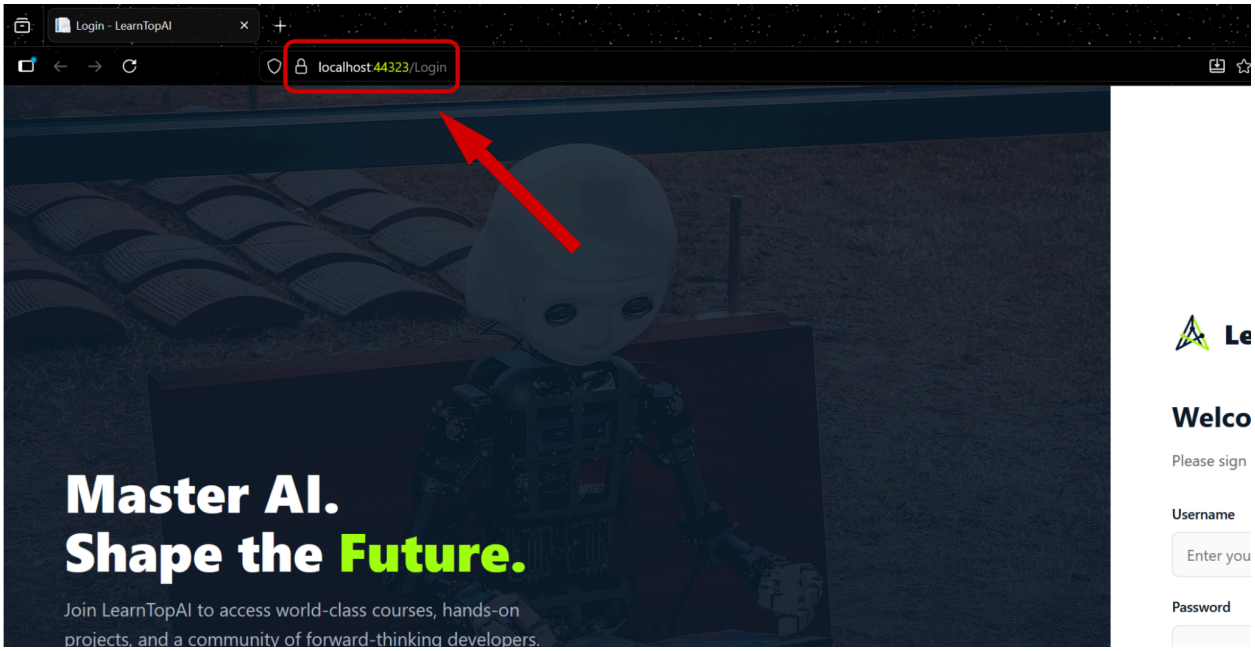
2.3 Start the Local Server

- Click the green **IIS Express** play button at the top to run your project.
- Your browser will open the website.



2.4 Find Your Port Number

- Look at the address bar in your browser.
- Identify the port number (for example, in `https://localhost:44323/`, the port is **44323**, highlighted in green in the screenshot below).
- Keep the project running! Do not close Visual Studio or the browser.



Step 3: Create the Public Tunnel

3.1 Start the Tunnel

- Open `ngrok.exe`.
- Type the routing command using your specific port number. Make sure to include exact spacing!
- Example command for secure local ports:
  `ngrok http https://localhost:44323 --host-header="localhost:44323"`
- Press Enter.

3.2 Verify the Connection

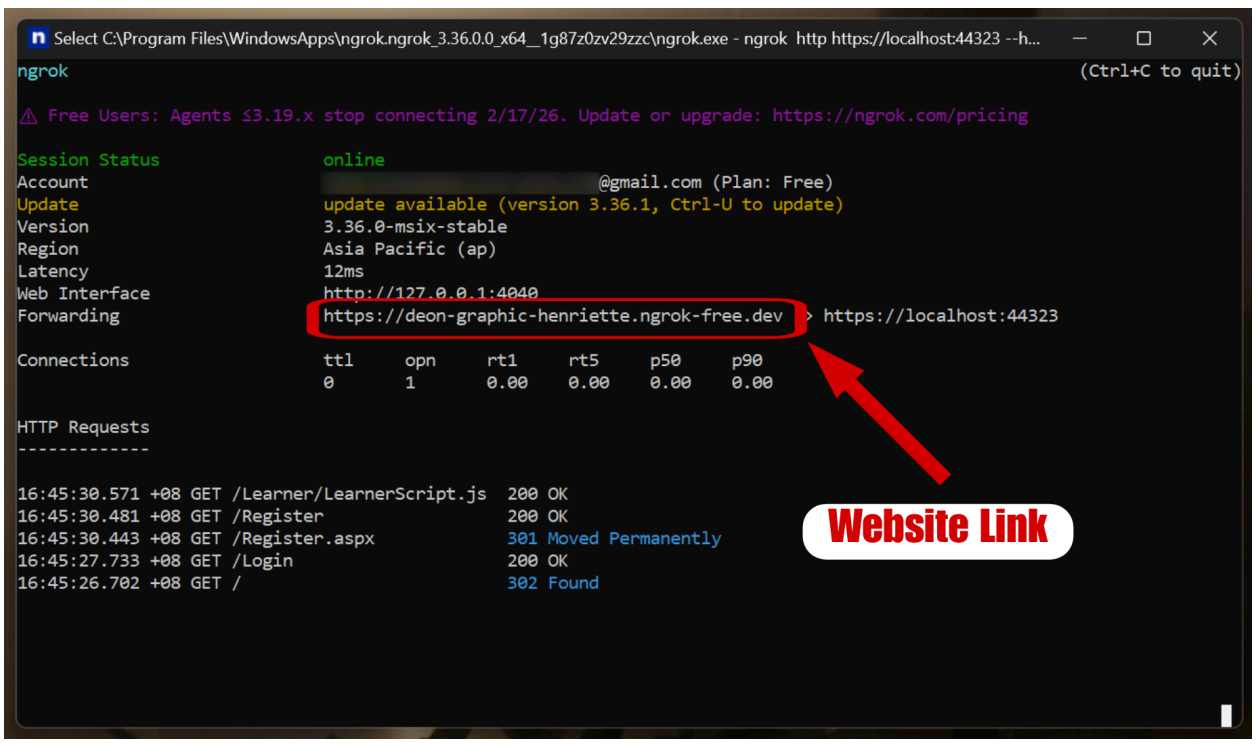
- The Command Prompt screen will clear and show an ngrok status dashboard.
- Look for the line that says **Session Status**. It should say **online**.

3.3 Find the Forwarding URL

- In the ngrok Command Prompt window, look for the line that starts with **Forwarding**.
- Copy the generated web address (e.g., https://random-text.ngrok-free.app).

3.4 Share the Link

- Send this link to anyone you want!
- **Important Note:** Because this is a free development tunnel, visitors will see a standard security warning page. Tell them to click **Visit Site** or **Advanced -> Continue** to access your project.



Troubleshooting

Problem: `ERR_NGROK_8012` (no such host)

- **Cause:** Formatting error in the command line, usually a missing space.
- **Fix:** Ensure there is a space between the port number and the `--host-header` flag. Restart the command prompt and try again.

Problem: `ERR_NGROK_3004` (invalid or incomplete HTTP response)

- **Cause:** ngrok is trying to send standard HTTP traffic to a port strictly reserved for secure HTTPS (like port 44323).
- **Fix:** Stop ngrok (`Ctrl + C`). Add `https://` to the localhost target in your command: `ngrok http https://localhost:PORT --host-header="localhost:PORT"`

Problem: The connection drops or the site stops loading

- **Cause:** Your local server went to sleep or Visual Studio stopped running.
- **Fix:** Ensure your project is still actively running via IIS Express in Visual Studio.

FAQ - Quick Answers

Q: Will ngrok charge me money?

A: No. The basic tunneling features are completely free.

Q: How long does the link last?

A: The link lasts until you close the Command Prompt window or stop ngrok. If you restart ngrok, it will generate a completely new, randomized link.

Q: Is it safe?

A: Yes. It only shares the specific port you assign it, not your whole computer.

Summary

What you learned:

- Download and authenticate a tunneling tool.
- Identify local development ports.
- Route local traffic to the public internet securely.
- Troubleshoot common command-line errors.

Your achievement:

- Website accessible from anywhere.
- Professional live-testing environment.
- Zero-cost temporary deployment.

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